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Women to Women

DRAFT DIALOGUE GUIDE

ABOUT THE GUIDE

This document has been developed for the Women-to-Women Project. It serves as a guide for facilitators and project teams involved in hosting women-led dialogue sessions. It outlines the objectives of the dialogue, the engagement methodology, the logistics and administration of participatory sessions, as well as post-dialogue actions and learning.

It is also a living document that will continue to improve based on the experiences of the research team, facilitators, and social actors (participants in the research) during implementation.

The Women-to-Women Security Project (W2WS) is funded by the Conflict, Stability and Security Fund (CSSF). The funding comes from the Integrated Security Fund, with the objective of improving the security of women and girls by enhancing their meaningful participation in security dialogues. The project seeks to help women and girls experience a greater sense of security and protection, while also contributing to the reduction of local clan-related violence.

WHAT IS WOMEN-LED DIALOGUE?

The "Dialogue" is a twofold phase within the Participatory Action Research (PAR) framework adopted by the project. This participatory process provides a mechanism for women to deliberate, engage, and strengthen their collective agency and decision-making. The dialogues are conducted in safe spaces where women feel valued and physically as well as emotionally secure. Within the PAR framework, dialogue emphasizes engagement with co-researchers and the development and implementation of context-appropriate strategies aimed at empowerment and transformation at various levels.

The two phases of dialogue include:

Dialogue for strategizing and decision-making

This phase follows the research and analysis stage, where women collaboratively identify the key factors influencing their sense of security and safety, while also critically reflecting on the findings. It leads to collective actions, solutions, and initiatives that enhance community security for women and girls, building on existing survival strategies.

Dialogue for learning and networking

This phase focuses on post-action reflection and exchange. It facilitates broader collective learning and conflict transformation, enabling women to unite with other groups and platforms, strengthen alliances, and build momentum for change. It also emphasizes expansion and knowledge sharing on a wider scale.

METHODOLOGY

PRE DIALOGUE

The dialogue sessions utilize a mixed-methods research approach grounded in Participatory Action Research (PAR). This includes a pre-dialogue analysis phase, during which a set of trigger reflection questions is designed to guide the discussions.

As Reason and Bradbury (2008) describe, PAR is *"an orientation to inquiry that seeks to create participative communities of inquiry, characterized by engagement, curiosity, and question posing."*

The pre-dialogue phase builds community linkages and trust through participatory systems mapping. Data is gathered on security needs, threats, influences, and conflict dynamics—issues directly shaping women's sense of security. These findings are then validated and critically reflected upon to form the foundation of the dialogue.

PAR in the W2W project engages researchers, facilitators, and women social actors to deepen understanding of women's perceptions of safety and to raise collective awareness of their situation. The ultimate goal is to enable collective action for change. This method ensures that both researchers/project staff and women participants jointly frame the questions, lead the dialogue, analyze findings, and determine which products and actions are most useful in driving meaningful change.

AIM OF THE DIALOGUE

Dialogues are designed to address the specific issues identified during the research and analysis phase. They incorporate both horizontal components (dialogue among women participants) and vertical components (dialogue between women and other stakeholders), as outlined in the SOR and the inception report.

DIALOGUE: STRATEGIZING AND DECISION MAKING

As stated above, once the project research team, facilitators, and women social actors have reflected on the findings of the PSM, they will plan dialogues—either among themselves to develop solutions and action plans, or with other stakeholders, including formal and informal security actors.

After this phase, women may return to the research and analysis stage to reflect on the dialogue outcomes. From there, they move into the next phase of action planning and identifying initiatives.

POST- DIALOGUE

The action plans are presented to the project team, where women prioritize the initiatives they consider most crucial. These may be supported and funded through the grant mechanism or pursued in collaboration with other projects.

DIALOGUE: NETWORKING AND LEARNING

Once initiatives have been implemented, women will be ready to engage in dialogue with other groups beyond Baidoa. These exchanges provide opportunities to share learning and adapt action plans, creating the potential for expansion and replication of the PAR approach and dialogue process.

PLANNING THE DIALOGUE

PRE-DIALOGUE PSM

This research phase empowers women to identify and map security threats, vulnerabilities, and key actors, while also strengthening collective analysis.

Developing the trigger questions and Critical thinking

This phase focuses on developing critical thinking among women through a set of trigger questions. These questions are designed to facilitate critical analysis of women's needs, the factors influencing their sense of security and safety, as well as the broader context and relevant stakeholders. The trigger questions are based on the findings of the PSM.

Some examples are listed below:

Issues

What is the origin of this issue?
How has this issue been addressed so far?
Who is suffering most from this issue?

Context

What is the history of this issue?

Actors

Who are the primary actors?
Who is most influential (positively and negatively)?
What is the interest of the actors?

Solutions

What are entry points to solving this issue?
Who should be involved in the solution?
What are the actions?
What are the risks and costs associated with this solution?

LOCATION & INVITING PARTICIPANTS

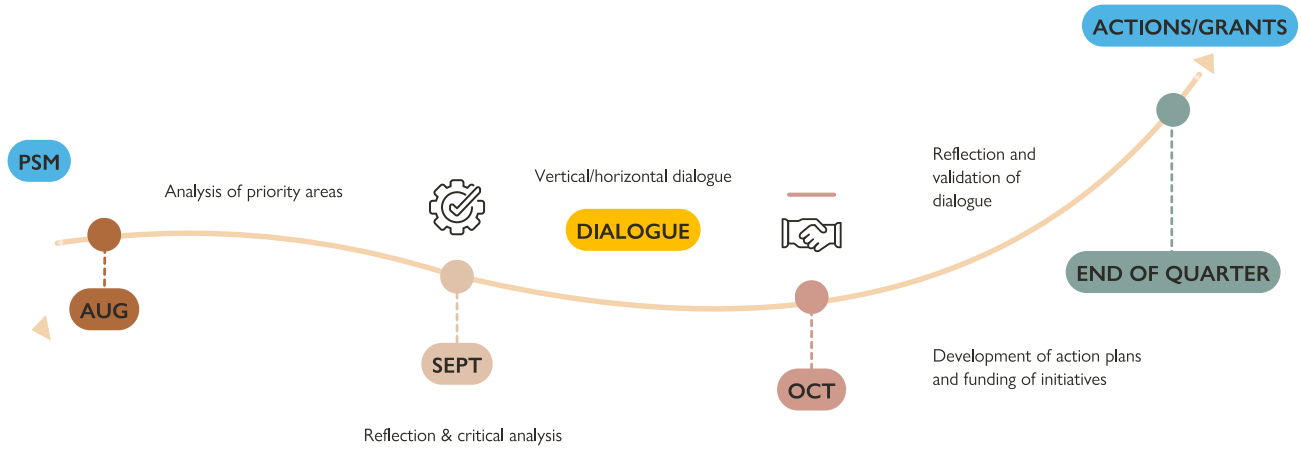
The venue should be inviting and conducive to engaging conversation, neutral, and make participants feel secure and at ease. Suitable venues may include community centers, women-only spaces such as wedding halls, or CSO offices.

DIALOGUE DURATION AND TIMELINES

The duration and frequency of dialogues can vary—from a few hours to several days or weeks, and from one-off sessions to multiple intermittent, progressive conversations. Under W2WS, given the nature of the programme, the context, and the issues at hand, there is a need for a gradual and organic process. These dialogues go beyond simple community conversations or checklists; their value lies in structuring sustained engagement, learning, action planning, implementation of outputs, and solutions. W2WS will conduct an incremental dialogue process aimed at expanding safe spaces for women to engage in meaningful dialogue.

Dialogue	Activity	Timeline
Pre- dialogue	PSM Framing the trigger questions	1 Day
Dialogue	Dialogue both vertical and horizontal Report writing and recommendation	1-2 days (2-3 weeks after PSM) 4-5 Days
Post dialogue	Feedback and implementation of dialogue outcomes, actions, and initiatives	2 weeks after dialogue
M&E and learning	Evaluation and Impacts: Iterations and Updated Project Indicators	On-going

QUARTERLY TIMELINE



PROCESSES AND ADMINISTRATION OF DIALOGUE

PSM SELECTION OF PANEL

» Select a panel of 20–30 women from diverse backgrounds in Baidoa, representing different categories and sharing interests in the priority issue identified.

» Panel members should be local, well-informed about their district, and willing to share their experiences regarding women in their communities.

» Members should commit to participating in subsequent dialogues, both horizontal and vertical.

» They should be regarded by other women as credible and trusted.

LOGISTICS

» Contact participants at least a week in advance to inform them about the PSM and dialogue.

» Organize transportation to and from the panel and dialogue venue, where necessary.

» Gather relevant information on security and safety prior to travel and return.

» Identify and arrange any other logistics needed to ensure a smooth and efficient event. For example, plan discussions early enough for participants to return the same day, where applicable.

» Communicate non-monetary provisions, such as meals and snacks.

» Identify a suitable venue that is a safe space—free from distractions, away from noisy areas, and discreet enough to avoid drawing attention.

» Schedule appropriately, avoiding prayer and meal times.

» Finalize the participant list before the end of the PSM and dialogue.

» Ensure diversity and inclusion to achieve broad representation of women

DIALOGUE

PSM SELECTION OF PANEL

» Create a comfortable environment that enables women to feel safe sharing their views.

» Arrange seating in a circle, ensuring the setup respects local culture and norms.

» Set up recording equipment, obtain participants' permission, and explain why recording is necessary. Only record with participants' consent.

CLIMATE SETTING

» The moderator/facilitator should begin with a brief introduction, welcoming participants, stating the purpose of the panel or dialogue, and outlining logistics, including the expected duration of the session.

Note to facilitator:

Explain the purpose of the dialogue. For example:

» "This panel/dialogue is organized for women representatives of (location) to discuss solutions to current issues affecting women's security and safety (example issue). The dialogue aims to address these issues and engage relevant stakeholders."

» Obtain consent. Confirm that participation is voluntary, participants may skip questions, and they are comfortable with recording.

» Introductions. Each participant briefly states their name, role, and key concerns or highlights from their district (max 3 minutes).

Set ground rules. Ideally developed collaboratively. For example:

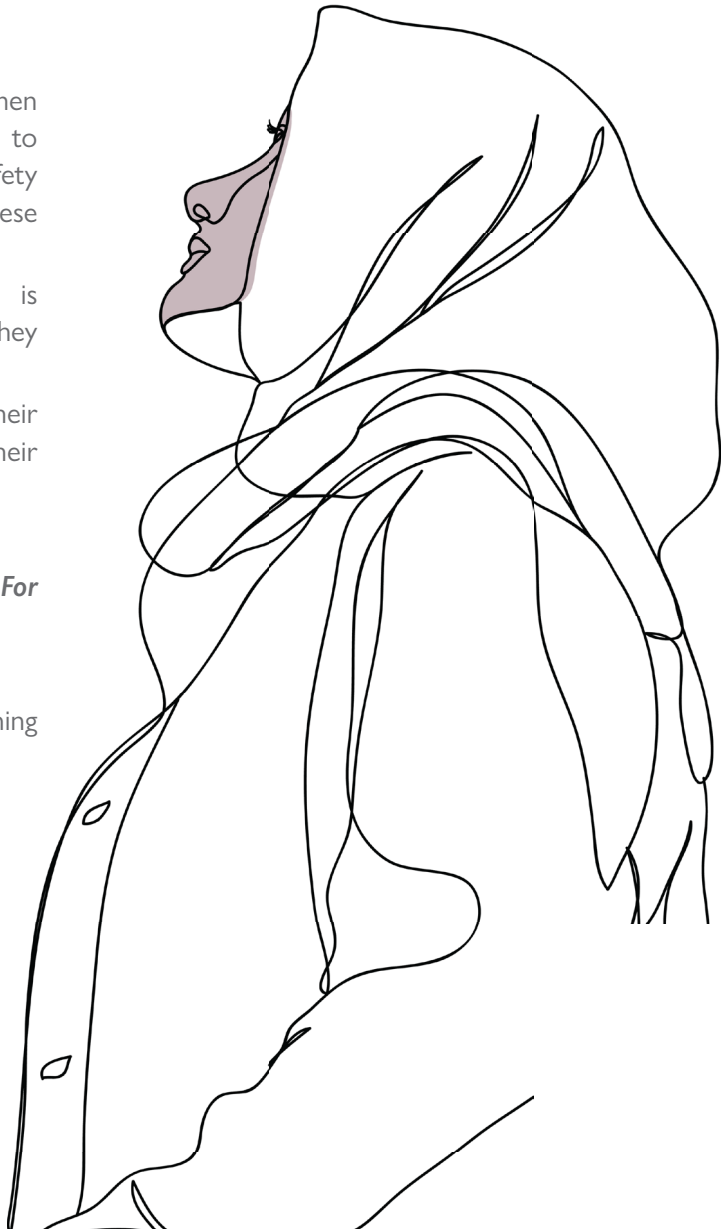
» No one is right or wrong; opinions may differ.

» Focus on understanding perspectives, not winning arguments.

» Respect others' views and speak one at a time.

» Switch mobile phones off or to silent.

» Listen actively and wait for your turn.



DIALOGUE TEAM

The dialogues will be hosted collaboratively by the project team and representatives from women's networks.

Facilitation tips:

» Ability to ask probing and follow up questions
» Able to facilitate critical thinking (ask participants to reflect on their own role and influence in the issue)
» Summarizing conversation
» Focusing discussion as well shifting focus
» Managing conflict

DIALOGUE OUTLINE

Outline:

Use preset open-ended questions to guide the session. Structure the session as follows:

» Introduction
» Setting ground rules
» Discussion of the issue
» Breaks
» Conclusion

Facilitating the discussion:

» Be ready and conversant with the trigger/ the questions issues
» Ask the right questions
» Apply active listening
» If necessary, you can divide the participants in groups
» Manage the dialogue and potential conflict. Make sure the dialogue doesn't turn to be a debate and is not about winning an argument
» Ensure participants reflect on critical issues

POST DIALOGUE

» Facilitators identifies areas of common grounds and share back with participants for validation.
» Once validated, the facilitator opens the floor for recommendations and solutions on way forward.

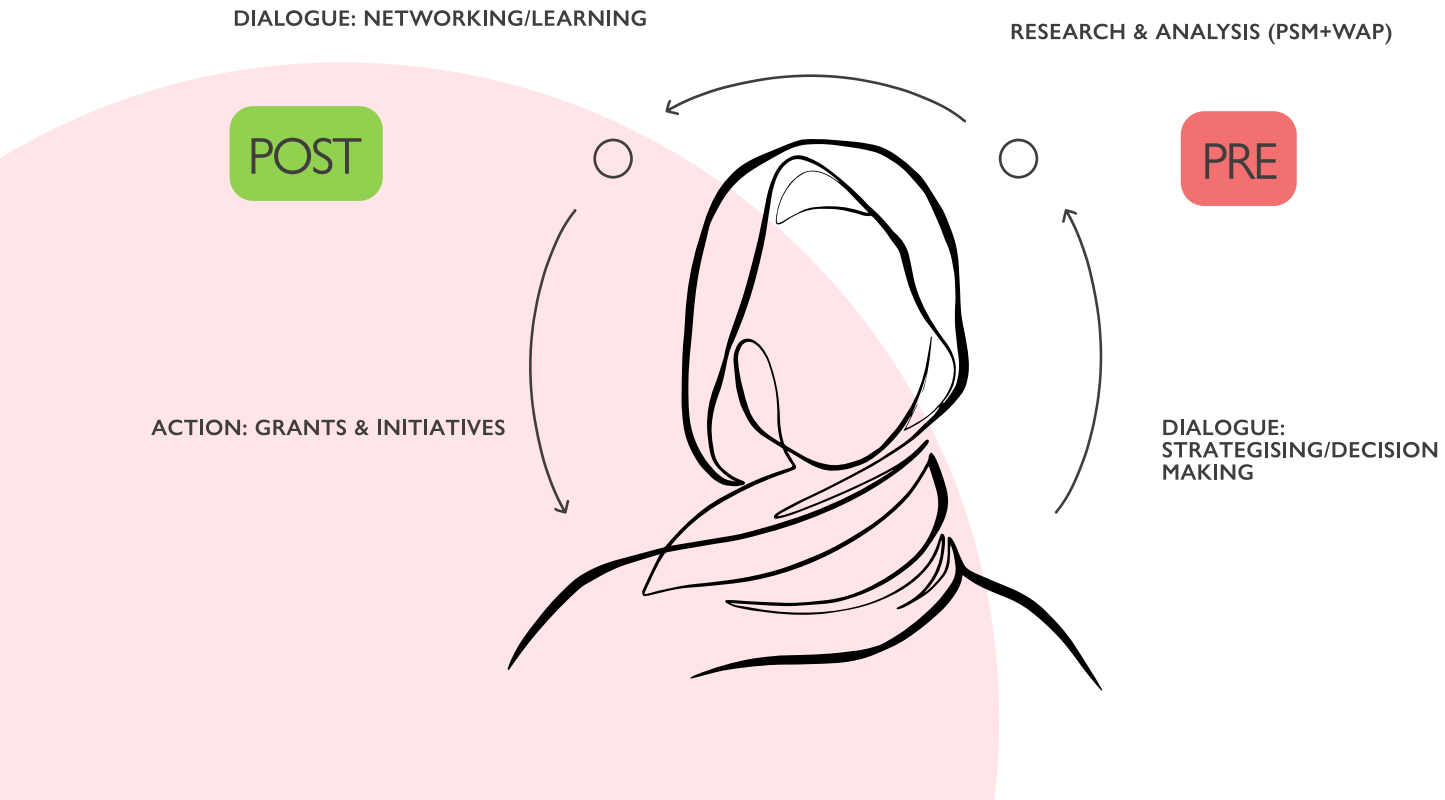
REPORT AND RECOMMENDATION

In consultation with the rest of the hosting team, the facilitator leads the report writing and formulation of recommendations. The report will then be shared with relevant stakeholders and clients.

IMPLEMENTING DIALOGUE OUTPUT

The dialogues go beyond simple community conversations; their value lies in fostering sustained engagement, learning, collective action, and decision-making. The project will conduct follow-up vertical or horizontal dialogues to review agreed actions, assess progress, and identify successes and setbacks.

MONITORING & EVALUATION

Monitoring and evaluation (M&E) will be conducted throughout the dialogue process by IOM. The aim is to capture key case stories demonstrating women's ability to critically analyze, reflect, and enhance decision-making processes. Tools will include observational analysis and pre- and post-beneficiary feedback mechanisms (BFMs).

The process will also be evaluated based on inclusivity, organization methods, level of engagement, and participation. Outputs and outcomes will be assessed according to the development of action plans, agreements reached, and the creation or strengthening of social and political capital.